We call for the removal of the Terrebonne Bike Path Between Madison and Cavendish during the winter

- November 22, 2024

Below is a copy of a letter I have sent to the City of Montreal Côte des Neiges-NDG Borough vis-a-vis a request for the removal of the Terrebonne Bike Path, between Madison and Cavendish, for the winter.

We kindly request that this letter be tabled as public correspondence at the December Borough Council meeting.

We are writing in light of a recent accident involving a school bus and a parent's vehicle that occurred directly in front of St. Monica Elementary School. Thankfully, no one was seriously injured. However, both the bus and the car sustained considerable damage, and the students onboard the bus were trapped for ten minutes due to the door being obstructed—an alarming situation that highlights the urgency of addressing safety concerns on Terrebonne Avenue.



We firmly believe that the accident was a direct result of the Borough's redesign of Terrebonne Avenue which included narrowing the roadway to accommodate bike paths on both sides. The section in front of St. Monica Elementary is especially problematic, as pre-existing sidewalk extensions were left in place, further reducing the already constrained space for vehicular traffic. The road has become extraordinarily narrow, leaving insufficient room for vehicles to safely maneuver.

The Borough's recent announcement that the bike path will remain operational during the winter months exacerbates the safety risks. This decision, in our view, is both reckless and dismissive of the needs of children and families in favor of a limited number of cyclists likely to use the bike path during the winter.

It is disappointing that the English Montreal School Board's repeated attempts to voice legitimate safety concerns have been ignored. On February 5, I wrote to the Borough on behalf of the EMSB, objecting to the bike path project due to its impact on:

- Pupil pick-up and drop-off logistics;
- Reduced parking for staff and parents;
- Danger posed to students crossing the bike path after disembarking school buses; and

- Heightened challenges for special needs students at the Mackay Centre and Philip E. Layton School.

Principals from Willingdon School, St. Monica School, Mackay Centre School, and Philip E. Layton School also wrote detailed letters outlining their specific concerns, including:

- Cyclists failing to stop when school bus safety arms are extended;
- The removal of secure drop-off zones for special needs students; and
- A significant reduction in parking spaces.

Despite these thorough submissions, the Borough has failed to address these concerns. Our schools feel marginalized, as their needs have been overshadowed by the Borough's prioritization of the cycling community.

The lack of meaningful consultation in this matter has been deeply disheartening. The recent, unilateral decision to maintain the Terrebonne bike path year-round, without any consultation, feels like a blatant disregard for the safety and well-being of our school communities.

In light of these ongoing issues, we are requesting the following immediate actions:

1. The removal of the bike path between Madison Avenue and Cavendish Boulevard for the winter months. This would alleviate safety risks for St. Monica Elementary School, Mackay Centre, and Philip E. Layton School communities.

2. The creation of a joint committee comprising EMSB specialists and Borough traffic officials to collaboratively design safer conditions for the spring.

The Borough's handling of this issue has been deeply disappointing. Despite assurances in late 2023 that our concerns would be taken into account, the final project proceeded unchanged. While it may align with the Borough Council majority's political agenda, it does so at the expense of the safety of vulnerable students and families.

We urge the Borough to take immediate corrective action to prioritize safety over politics.